

Actinides

This series of metals appears along the bottom of the periodic table, underneath the lanthanides. The group gets its name from actinium, the first member in the series. The heaviest naturally occurring elements of all, such as thorium and uranium, are actinides, along with many elements created artificially.

Radioactivity

Actinides are highly radioactive elements. Given enough time, the atoms of all these elements will break up and decay away. While thorium and uranium are the most stable and will last for billions of years, some other actinides have atoms that break up in a fraction of a second. Actinides are used as nuclear fuels for making electricity. Nuclear reactor complexes include hazardous areas with radiation warning symbols that alert people of the dangers within.

Radioactivity blasting from the uranium rod creates a blue glow. The heat from the fuel makes steam for generating electricity.

**Nuclear rod
heating water**



Radiation symbol